

6 Rites of Passage

MAKEOVERS From dressing up their dolls, pre-teen girls have moved on to adorning themselves. Shaving their legs is the biggest indicator of young adulthood. For boys, it's using hair gel and deos.

SLEEPOVERS It's a night of gossip and giggles. Who is dating whom? Who has a crush on the cute drummer from high school? Who has started wearing a bra already? Strictly for the girls. Boys have their own version. It's the wilderness camp.

MALL MANIA Girls meet for coffee and discuss what to wear at the next party. Boys meet for bowling, catching movies or just checking out girls.

SIBLING RIVALRY Sisters fight over clothes, make-up and boys while brothers try to establish their domination. The elder one gets upset if the younger one is already a 'Bond' in school.

GAMES THEY PLAY Truth and dare is the favourite pre-teen game, where one is dared to kiss their secret crush or admit they have one. Boys love to have day-long Playstation matches, which allow them to be Ronaldo, John Cena or Brian Lara. Girls are big on online games, tending their farms and baking a batch of brownies on Farmville and Restaurant City.

ROMANCE VS SEX While girls read *Sweet Valley* and *The Twilight* series, boys are busy exploring explicit magazines and movies.

advanced puberty is the single biggest reason for precocious pre-teens. At the Postgraduate Institute of Medical Education & Research (PGI), Chandigarh, doctors now regularly counsel mothers who are unsettled by the fact that their daughters have had their first period much earlier than them. "This is nothing unusual. It is an established medical fact that girls and boys are reaching puberty earlier than it happened some decades ago," says Puneet Singhi, a paediatrician at the PGI. Some explanations for it are still in the realm of educated conjecture. As N. Shalini, a Chennai-based psychiatrist, says, "Our brain usually gauges time using light and darkness. The hypothesis is that since our exposure to artificial light is more today, it misleads the brain which controls secretion of hormones. Villagers who are less exposed to artificial light are less prone to early puberty."

Early puberty means greater emphasis on the body image. Meet girls with anorexic bodies and poker straight hair, who pester their parents about eating the right kind of "diet food" and demand more money for cosmetics. Catch boys who stock their bathroom shelves with deos and hair gels, who want their hair and clothes to mimic their favourite film or music icons. Their emerging bodies become the site for adornment, whether it is tattoos or piercing, nail extensions or nose rings. "Being emo-goth (emotional gothic) is being cool," says 12-year-old Harsh Bindra from Delhi, who just got his eyebrow pierced.

Add to it the public image transmitted to them through the media. Nine-year-olds watch reality shows, where they are often forced to act as adults. As sociologist Patricia Oberoi from Delhi says, "Some dances in these shows are shockingly explicit and parents are a party to it. The media has developed a consumerist attitude towards pre-teens." Adds Delhi-based psychologist Samir Parikh: "The greatest influence for children in this age group is the behaviour of their immediate seniors. They want to be like them." With most children of this age group relying on observational learning, they are very sharp to notice the difference in the way teachers and parents treat teenagers. While tweens are still treated as babies, teenagers are considered young adults. This increases the urge for them to grow up faster. Anyway, points out sociologist Rajni Palriwala, even among the middle classes, the age of marriage has increased not that long ago. "Our children have seen and do see and hear a lot of sexual activity around them, in their homes, extended households, and neigh-



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